

CHAPTER – 3

UNITED NATIONS

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The UN was formed following the devastating World War II, with the aim of preventing future global-scale conflicts. It was a successor to the ineffective **League of Nations**. The representatives of 50 governments met in San Francisco on 25 April 1945, to draft what would become the **UN Charter**. The Charter was adopted on 25 June 1945 and came into effect on 24 October 1945.

UNITED NATIONS FUNCTIONS

In accordance with the Charter, the organization's objectives include maintaining international peace and security, protecting human rights, delivering humanitarian aid, promoting sustainable development, and upholding international law. At its founding, the UN had 51 member states; this number grew to 193 in

2011, representing the vast majority of the world's sovereign states.

UNITED NATIONS STRUCTURE

The UN is structured around five principal organs:

1. General Assembly
2. United Nations Security Council (UNSC)
3. Economic and Social Council (ECOSOC)
4. International Court of Justice
5. UN Secretariat.

A sixth principal organ, the Trusteeship Council, suspended operations on 1 November 1994, upon the independence of Palau, the last remaining UN trustee territory.

A brief table about their primary function is given below:

PRINCIPAL ORGANS OF THE UNITED NATIONS

Name of the Organ	Primary Function	Primary Tasks of the Organ
UN General Assembly	Deliberative assembly of all the UN member states	• May resolve non-compulsory recommendations to states or suggestions to the Security Council (UNSC); • Decides on the admission of new members, following a proposal by the UNSC; • Adopts the budget; • Elects the non-permanent members of the UNSC; all members of ECOSOC; the UN Secretary-General (following his/her proposal by the UNSC); and the fifteen judges of the International Court of Justice (ICJ). Each country has one vote.
UN Secretariat	Administrative organ of the UN	• Supports the other UN bodies administratively (for example, in the organization of conferences, the writing of reports and studies the preparation of the budget); • Its chairperson – the UN Secretary-General – is elected by the General Assembly for a five-year mandate and is the UN's foremost representative.
International Court of Justice	Universal court of international law	• Decides disputes between states that recognize its jurisdiction; • Issues legal opinions; • Renders judgment by relative majority. Its fifteen judges are elected by the UN General Assembly for nine-year terms.

UN Security Council	Arbitrates international security issues	• Responsible for the maintenance of international peace and security; • May adopt compulsory resolutions; • Has fifteen members: five permanent members with veto power and ten elected non-permanent members (term – two years)
UN Economic and Social Council	For global economic and social affairs	• Responsible for cooperation between states concerning economic and social matters; • Coordinates cooperation between the numerous specialized agencies of UN; • Has 54 members, elected by the General Assembly to serve staggered three-year mandates.
UN Trusteeship Council	For administering trust territory (now disbanded)	• Was originally designed to manage former colonial possessions. • Has been inactive since 1994, when Palau, the last trust territory, attained independence.

WHAT ARE THE SPECIALIZED AGENCIES OF THE UN?

The UN Charter stipulates that each primary organ of the United Nations can establish various specialized agencies to fulfil its duties. There are 17 specialized agencies of the UN. They are mentioned in the table below:

United Nations Specialized Agencies			
Agency	Acronym	Headquarters	Founding Year
Food and Agriculture Organization	FAO	Rome, Italy	1945
International Telecommunication Union	ITU	Geneva, Switzerland	1865 (Joined UN in 1947)
International Fund for Agricultural Development	IFAD	Rome, Italy	1977
International Labour Organization	ILO	Geneva, Switzerland	1946
International Maritime Organization	IMO	London, United Kingdom	1948
International Monetary Fund	IMF	Washington, United States	1945
United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization	UNESCO	Paris, France	1946
World Health Organization	WHO	Geneva, Switzerland	1948
United Nations Industrial Development Organization	UNIDO	Vienna, Austria	1966
International Civil Aviation Organization	ICAO	Montreal, Canada	1944
World Intellectual Property Organisation	WIPO	Geneva, Switzerland	1967
International Fund for Agricultural Development	IFAD	Rome, Italy	1977
Universal Postal Union	UPU	Bern, Switzerland	1874
International Telecommunication Union	ITU	Geneva, Switzerland	1865
United Nations World Tourism Organization	UNWTO	Madrid, Spain	1974
World Meteorological Organisation	WMO	Geneva, Switzerland	1950
World Bank Group	WBG	Washington, D.C, USA	1944

UN AGENCIES AND ORGANISATIONS

There are several agencies, bodies, institutes and organisations that work under the UN system. Some of them predate the UN's establishment and were incorporated into the UN later on, while others were founded afterwards. They perform important functions across domains, regions and sectors. The table below mentions a few significant such organisations.

Important Agencies & Programs under the UN System			
Agency	Acronym	HQ	Founding Year
United Nations Environment Programme	UNEP	Nairobi, Kenya	1972
United Nations Children's Fund	UNICEF	New York, USA	1946
United Nations Population Fund	UNFPA	New York, USA	1967
United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees	UNHCR	Geneva, Switzerland	1950
United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime	UNODC	Vienna, Austria	1997
United Nations Interregional Crime and Justice Research Institute	UNICRI	Turin, Italy	1968
United Nations Office for Disaster Risk Reduction	UNDRR	Geneva, Switzerland	1999
United Nations Development Programme	UNDP	New York, USA	1965
United Nations University	UNU	Tokyo, Japan	1972
United Nations Conference on Trade and Development	UNCTAD	Geneva, Switzerland	1964
International Atomic Energy Agency	IAEA	Vienna, Austria	1957
United Nations Human Settlement Programme	UN-Habitat	Nairobi, Kenya	1978
Joint United Nations Programme on HIV/AIDS	UNAIDS	Geneva, Switzerland	1994
World Food Programme	WFP	Rome, Italy	1961
Office of the High Commissioner for Human Rights	OHCHR	Geneva, Switzerland	1993

UN CONVENTIONS

The United Nations sets up international conventions, which may be legally binding on parties, on various issues and domains. Some of the important conventions, protocols, etc. are mentioned in the table below. You can read more about the conventions by clicking on their names.

UNCLOS	UNFCCC
UNCBD	UNCAT
UNCRPD	Minamata Convention
Montreal Protocol	Kigali Amendment
UNCCD	Kyoto Protocol
GEF	Rio Summit (UNCED)
ITLOS	UNCRC
UNTOC	CEDAW

INDIA AND THE UN

India was among the founding members of the United Nations. Even before achieving independence, India had signed the Declaration by the United Nations at Washington, D.C. in 1944, and also participated in the United Nations Conference on International Organization at San Francisco from 25 April to 26 June 1945. As one of the

original members of the United Nations, India enthusiastically supports the purposes and principles of the UN and has made significant contributions in implementing the goals of the organisation. The UN field networks in India are the largest anywhere in the world through the many offices, programmes and funds currently at work in the country.

Today, there are 26 UN agencies in India. Some of the milestones that the UN has made in India through its agencies are elaborated upon below:

1. Food and Agriculture Organization (FAO):

0. When FAO began its India operations in 1948, its priority was to transform India's food and farm sectors through technical inputs and support for policy development.
1. Over the years, FAO has made major inroads in resolving issues such as access to food, nutrition, livelihoods, rural development and sustainable agriculture. With the **Sustainable Development Goals** in full swing, the FAO's primary focus will be on improving India's sustainable agricultural practices.

2. International Fund for Agricultural Development (IFAD):

0. IFAD and the Government of India have achieved significant results in investing in the **commercialization** of **smallholding-agriculture** and building small farmers' capacity to increase incomes from market opportunities.
1. IFAD-supported projects have also provided women with access to financial services, such as by linking women's self-help groups with commercial banks.

3. UNAIDS:

0. India has worked with the UN on the Joint United Nations Programme on **HIV/AIDS (UNAIDS)**. The main aim of the programme is to help prevent new HIV infections, care for people living with HIV and mitigate the impact of the epidemic.
1. Between 2001 and 2012 the total number of cases of the disease in India fell down by 50%, one of the highest in the world at that time. So far, India has managed to continue the trend.

4. Asian and Pacific Centre for Transfer of Technology (APCTT):

0. This is a UNESCAP regional institute established in 1977. It works in the fields of technology transfer, information and innovation management.

5. International Monetary Fund: India has been working closely with the IMF. For more on this, please check the linked article on IMF in the table above.

6. UNESCO:

0. India has been closely associated with the UNESCO. India has been continuously re-elected to the Executive Board of UNESCO since 1946.
1. A UNESCO Category I Institute dedicated to education for peace and sustainable development was established in 2012 and is called the Mahatma Gandhi Institute of Education for Peace and Sustainable Development (MGIEP). It is located in New Delhi.
2. There are also several **UNESCO World Heritage Sites in India**. For more on this, click the linked article.

7. World Health Organisation (WHO): WHO has been working closely with the Indian government to improve health outcomes. It has played a stellar part in eradicating several diseases such as cholera, controlling others like malaria, TB, etc. For more on WHO and India, you can check the WHO linked article from the table above.

Similarly, other organisations have also played a great role in India and helped in its progress towards development, health and economic improvement. For details of each organisation's role in India, you can go through the respective articles from the table above.

India's Contribution towards the UN

India has been an active member of the UN since its inception. In 1946, India became the first country to raise the issues of racism and apartheid in South Africa in the UN forum.

- India played an important part in the drafting of the Universal Declaration of Human Rights in 1948. Read more about the contribution of **Hansa Mehta** in this regard.
- The first woman president of the UNGA was an Indian, Vijayalakshmi Pandit, in 1953.
- India's contribution to the UNSC can be read at the UNSC article from the first table on this page.
- India has contributed immensely to **UN Peacekeeping Missions** in various parts of the world.
- India has sent her peacekeeping troops to Korea, Egypt, Congo, Haiti, Angola, Somalia, Liberia, Rwanda, Lebanon, South Sudan, etc.
- India has been regularly one of the largest contributor of troops to the missions.
- Mahatma Gandhi's ideals of non-violence resonate deeply with the UN's principles. In 2007, the UN declared Gandhi's birth anniversary of October 2 as the 'International Day of Non-violence'.
- In 2014, the UNGA declared that 21st June would be observed as **International Yoga Day**. Read more on this in the linked article.